

Raxz stepped out of the chamber. Immediately, the air shifted—a faint odor clung to his senses. Rotten eggs and something else, something hovering just beyond recognition. Sulfur, perhaps, or the residue of magic pushed too hard against the world's grain. He filed it away with the clinical precision Javelin had taught him.

The moment the door sealed behind him with a final click, his discipline fractured.

Motionless in the corridor, he stared at his own hand. Javelin's hand had rested there—had *lingered*—before pulling away. Carefully, without drawing attention from the few servants passing at this hour, Raxz raised his hand to his cheek. The spot where Javelin's lips had briefly touched the signet ring still held phantom warmth. For one stolen moment, he let that warmth linger against his skin before lowering his hand, disguising the gesture as warming his face. Necessary in spring, he told himself. Though spring had already turned mild, and everyone knew it.

The lie was transparent, even to himself.

His pace measured, his bearing correct, Raxz began walking toward his father's office. Servants in the corridors—those who bothered to look up—offered the small bow reserved for the Emperor's heir. A tilt of his head acknowledged each. Nothing more. His mind was elsewhere, spiraling inward like a vortex pulling thought after thought into its center.

*How dare he.*

Sharp and sudden, the thought struck. *How dare Javelin correct me? Stop me before I could ask what I've been building courage to ask for years?*

His jaw tightened. Today was supposed to be different. Months spent refining his technique, proving to Javelin that they operated on equal footing now—peers, not merely master and apprentice. He'd planned to demonstrate the blink, that difficult, dangerous technique, and then ask. Finally, *finally*, ask the question consuming him for longer than he cared to admit.

But Javelin shut him down. Not with cruelty, but with that infuriating mixture of instruction and rejection. *You exposed your signature. You made noise when you teleported. You failed.*

*Because you know me intimately, he wanted to shout. Because we've trained together, learned together, spent more time in each other's presence than anyone in this palace. How could I possibly hide myself from you?*

The contradiction twisted inside him, bitter and aching. If Javelin knew him so well—knew his magical resonance the way a musician knows a familiar instrument—then surely he

understood *why* Raxz's signature was exposed. Surely he understood that such intimacy made deception impossible.

Unless that was the point. Unless Javelin's correction was itself a message: *This is why we cannot. This is why you must learn to hide from me most of all.*

His footsteps echoed through marble as he processed this. The logic was sound. Cautious. Wise.

Also unbearable.

A servant carrying ledgers passed. Another hurried by with a feather duster. The palace moved around him, indifferent to his turmoil. A loud bang echoed somewhere nearby—maintenance worker, probably, handling equipment poorly. Raxz barely registered it. Instead, his mind spiraled deeper, cataloging the small duties appearing on his schedule lately. Briefings his father used to conduct personally. Decisions that should have fallen to the Emperor, now delegated to him. Shadow responsibilities accumulating like dust.

*Is Father simply offloading his burden onto my shoulders? Or is this something else entirely?*

Javelin always said his father was incapable of true delegation, that the ministers were mostly ceremonial. But was Javelin wrong? Or was the Emperor genuinely preparing his heir piece by piece for what was to come?

The questions multiplied. Beneath them all lurked the larger, more terrifying question: *Could I walk away from all of this—the duty, the power, the empire itself—for him?*

As if answering his uncertainty, his father's voice crystallized in memory. Not present, but the echo of a thousand lessons, delivered in that precise, regal tone admitting no contradiction.

*An emperor is the first called to defend, the first called to attack, the first sacrifice demanded. An emperor is nothing without the people. The people are nothing without the emperor. The emperor is nothing but the will of the people made manifest. That will, that power, must always be upheld. If we lose the people, we lose power. If we lose power, the empire dies, and the people suffer. We are the first and last line of defense. The empire is the people, and the people are the empire. Always remember this. There is no reason why you should not be remembered among the greatest emperors to ever lead our realm.*

The words settled over him like armor. Heavy. Necessary. Suffocating.

Ahead, the massive doors to his father's office loomed, guarded by soldiers standing with the stillness of men trained to see everything and forget what they saw. This threshold

marked the boundary between private man and public duty. Once he crossed it, Raxz would perform the role expected: dutiful heir, competent administrator, the emperor-in-waiting.

He steeled himself. There would be time for personal feeling later—perhaps. Tonight there would be the gala, where courtesies would be observed and alliances maintained and the nine great houses would circle each other like predators assessing prey. Javelin would be there. They would exchange formal acknowledgments. The distance between them would be measured and visible and absolutely correct.

But first, he had to face his father.

Raxz straightened his shoulders, smoothed his expression, and approached the doors. The guards recognized him and moved to open them without a word. As the doors swung inward, he crossed the threshold into duty, leaving the last trace of his own desires behind.

Arctus made no immediate response. Raxz watched his father's face carefully, reading the minute shifts in expression—the way his jaw tightened, the flicker behind his eyes. Without seeing his father speak, without any audible response, Raxz understood with sudden, sickening clarity that he'd miscalculated. Pushed too hard. In his attempt to assert control, he'd made his father misstep—and worse, Arctus knew it.

The cold voice, when it finally came, sounded distant and somehow choked. "You may go."

Raxz turned and walked through the doors. Each step carried him further from the office, further from his father, into something that felt increasingly like drowning. The weight settling onto his shoulders had no source, no clear cause, yet it was undeniable. As the doors sealed shut behind him, nausea rolled through his stomach. No more maneuvering now. I've crossed a line.

He walked toward his chambers in a daze, his mind fractured between present and past. Lady Marcella. He had a vague childhood memory of her—a playmate when they were both six or seven at most, before the wars, before his father stopped smiling. Nothing more than children playing games. But now she was twenty-one, nearly an adult, and he knew nothing of who she'd become. Did she laugh? What brought her joy? Was she even willing to consider courtship with a prince arranged with her like a political maneuver?

And what of me? I can barely understand myself, much less what I'm meant to feel about Jave—

He stopped the thought before it could finish Javelin's name. Too dangerous, even in the privacy of his own mind.

No. This was different. This was strategy. An alliance between his father and House Kalvennor—a necessary move, politically important, meant to salvage imperial credibility with the noble families. The Empire still stood, technically, but its alliances were fragmenting like aged pottery. Every day, Raxz saw those fractures reflected in his father's face, mapped in silver threads of new hair, carved into lines of burden. The weight of holding a crumbling empire together was literally aging the Emperor before his son's eyes.

So this arrangement with Marcella wasn't cruelty. It was necessity. It was sacrifice.

Mid-step in the corridor, a terrible thought struck him: Was this simply another test? Another lesson designed to teach me what being Emperor truly means? Another way for Father to show me that personal desire is a luxury emperors cannot afford?

He resumed walking, slowly now, each footfall heavy with new understanding.

Is being Emperor worth the sacrifice of my own humanity? To choose the betterment of the realm over the betterment of an individual? Even if that individual is the most important person in my life?

His mind drifted backward, drawn by memory toward a day he hadn't consciously thought about in years. He must have been five or six—just before the wars, just before his father's smile disappeared from the world. Running through the Fields of Absolution, chasing a blue jay that kept just ahead, always tantalizingly out of reach.

Then a boy appeared—around Raxz's age, moving with an ease that made the pursuit look effortless. The blue jay landed on the boy's extended finger, calm and trusting. The boy spoke to the small bird with wonder that made Raxz stop running entirely.

"What a beautiful little bird. What a shame it would be if someone were to put you in a golden cage."

The innocence of that moment crystallized in memory: the boy's gentle voice, the bird's absolute trust, the unguarded expression of genuine feeling. That boy was Javelin—though Raxz hadn't known his name then, hadn't understood he was looking at the man who would teach him everything and become everything.

Is such innocence only a luxury for children? Or can it still be a mercy, even for those of us learning to carry empires?

He had no answer. Only the cold certainty that by tonight, he would have to lock that innocence away, perform the role expected, and pretend his heart wasn't already breaking.

Raxz reached his chambers and dismissed the servant waiting there with a single gesture. Alone, he stood in the center of the room for a long moment, letting that memory settle. Letting it hurt. Then he moved toward the wardrobe where his attire for the evening waited.

Two hours later, as the evening bells rang across the palace grounds, Raxz finished the final touches to his attire and studied his reflection with mounting dismay. The colors Lady Marcella of House Kalvennor chose could only be described as the massacre of a peacock. Silver roses intertwined with gold lilies across a backdrop that seemed to fight itself for dominance—hues that clashed and somehow lost the battle even as they tried to complement one another. The overall effect made him look less like an imperial heir and more like a traveling mummer.

Unbidden and unwanted, Javelin's voice echoed in his mind, that particular dry tone he used when pointing out strategic advantages Raxz missed: *Well now, Your Highness. With this disguise, I'm certain no one will be able to keep their eyes off you. Perfect distraction. Own it—a man who can't be ignored can't be underestimated.*

He was halfway tempted to use his abilities to alter the hues into something more regal and less garish. In truth, if Marcella had simply requested black attire with the same patterns rendered in gold and silver, it would have sufficed—would have been elegant, even. Would have complemented whatever atrocious color palette she'd chosen for herself far better than this peacock catastrophe.

But duty was duty. He had no choice but to wear it.

As he stepped out of his chambers, a subtle distortion rippled at the periphery of his awareness—a faint squeak in the air, the telltale compression when someone folded space carelessly. Someone just blinked nearby, though he couldn't discount other forms of translocation. The signature tasted metallic on his tongue, unfamiliar. Javelin's constant training kicked in reflexively: *Always be aware. Always notice.*

He disguised his awareness by brushing his sleeves and adjusting his cuffs, moving naturally while probing outward with his senses. Temperature shifts. Ambient noise. The faint scents carried on the air. Someone was watching. Or had been.

Descending toward the atrium, the guests increased in number. Their collective magical signatures began to swarm the outer reaches of his awareness—some warm like candlelight, others cold as winter iron, a few that tasted of flowers and others of ash. The

cacophony overwhelmed his senses, forcing him to pull back and throw up his mental walls hastily. *Too many people. Too much magical resonance competing for attention.*

The closer he drew to the atrium, the louder the announcer's voice became, formally naming and pronouncing each distinguished guest as they arrived.

Dreading but understanding his obligation, he slipped toward the entrance hall where he could greet guests, be greeted in turn, and—most importantly—wait for Lady Marcella. Protocol demanded they arrive together, or at least present themselves as a coordinated pair.

Minutes passed. She hadn't yet arrived.

Near the entrance, he scanned the crowd with practiced neutrality. He told himself he was watching for Marcella, though in truth he couldn't recall what she looked like now. His childhood memories were vague at best—a girl with a laugh, perhaps, but nothing concrete.

Within the depths of his mind, he kicked himself for what he was actually doing: searching for Javelin. Trying to catch a glimpse of him in the crowd, to see where he was coming from, what his attire looked like. Hoping—against all reason—that Javelin looked just as ridiculous as he did in this peacock nightmare.

At least then, they could suffer together.

"Your Highness."

A voice cut through his thoughts—smooth, polished, carrying the particular intonation of someone who'd spent years at court. Raxz turned to find Lord Theron of House Vandris approaching, a thin smile on his lips and a goblet of wine already in hand despite the gala not yet officially beginning.

"Lord Theron." Raxz inclined his head the precise degree protocol demanded. "I trust your journey to the palace was pleasant?"

"Pleasant enough." Theron's eyes swept over Raxz's attire with barely concealed amusement. "Though I see you've taken... an interesting approach to fashion this evening. House Kalvennor's colors, if I'm not mistaken? How very... diplomatic of you."

The barb was subtle but unmistakable. Raxz felt the eyes of nearby courtiers turning toward them, curious to see how the Prince would respond to such a thinly veiled insult.

*So it begins, he thought. The circling. The testing. The nine houses watching to see if I'll break.*

He met Theron's gaze with a smile that didn't reach his eyes. "Diplomacy is the foundation of empire, Lord Theron. Surely House Vandris understands that better than most, given your family's... delicate position regarding the southern trade negotiations?"

Theron's smile faltered slightly. The reminder of his house's political vulnerability landed exactly as Raxz intended.

Before either could continue, the announcer's voice rang out with sudden authority: "Lady Marcella Kalvennor!"

Raxz turned toward the entrance.

And there she was.

Lady Marcella presented herself at the entrance with extravagant bearing—regal posture, dignified stride, the picture of baronial grace. At least, her posture attempted grace. In truth, she was dressed exactly as he was: like a peacock being murdered.

At some basic level, Raxz would have appreciated being seen as a buffoon if he'd been alone in the humiliation. But now, seeing Marcella trapped in the same gaudy nightmare, he felt something unexpected: solidarity.

Their eyes met across the entrance hall. Automatically, as if choreographed by years of courtly training, they moved toward each other. Not attraction. Not desire. Pure courtesy, dictated by protocol and observed by every watching eye in the room.

*Well, Raxz thought as he approached, at least the evening can only improve from here. I've made a complete fool of myself, and Javelin is undoubtedly watching from somewhere, laughing. I wish I could see him just to show him exactly how I feel about this.*

But Javelin remained elusive, nowhere visible in the growing crowd.

They met halfway. Raxz extended his arm first, a formal gesture requesting Lady Marcella's hand. She offered it. He kissed her knuckles with practiced precision, then lifted his gaze to meet hers.

"My lady, you look very beautiful. Please, allow me to escort you to the evening's event." He offered his arm.

Marcella placed her hand on his arm, but carefully—almost gingerly—as if trying not to commit to the gesture fully. There was a subtle inference of misunderstanding between them, though Raxz couldn't determine if it originated from him toward her or her toward him. He felt it. Registered it. But continued with the performance nonetheless.

Together, they moved toward the Grand Hall where the assembled crowd waited.

Even as he walked, even as he performed the role of attentive escort, Raxz's eyes swept the room. Scanning faces. Searching for one particular figure. Hoping for just a glimpse of Javelin in—his friend, if nothing else remained between them.

But the crowd pressed in, and Javelin was nowhere to be found.

As Raxz and Marcella walked through the crowd, his senses began to acclimate to the environment. With each step, he drew another deep breath and slowly exhaled, centering himself. Grounding himself. Ready for anything. A gentle but quiet voice in the back of his mind—Javelin's voice—reminded him of the fundamentals.

*Though "teachings" is far too grand a word for what Javelin actually does, Raxz thought with faint amusement. Helpful hints. Tricks. Things he somehow picked up and decided to share. We're practically the same age. Brothers, almost. He's treated me like a brother.*

For an instant, his mind flashed back to earlier that day. The private room. When he'd allowed himself to be caught from behind, grappled, after he transported them—

Lost in that memory, he vaguely registered that without Lady Marcella's gentle maneuvering, he would have walked directly into several guests. Her hand on his arm subtly guided him left, then right, threading them through the press of bodies with surprising skill.

*Odd, he thought, studying her from the corner of his eye. How natural she makes this feel.*

Marcella seemed composed, well put together. But the most striking thing about her—the thing that crept into his awareness slowly—was that she didn't exactly move *around* people. Through some instinct or force of will, she made the other people move for *them*. The crowd parted before them like water around a ship's prow.

Then, almost sheepishly, Raxz remembered: *I'm a Prince. Of course people move aside.* Perhaps what he'd first perceived as Lady Marcella being imposing was simply her utilizing *his* authority in a way he'd never consciously considered. If he'd thought about it at all, he'd certainly never analyzed it the way he was now.

He began to look at Marcella with genuine interest. *Maybe beneath the murdered peacock outfit, there's actually a person of substance. Wit. Genuine intelligence.*

As they approached the Herald at the Grand Hall entrance, Raxz produced a card from his pocket and handed it over. The Herald raised his trumpet. The call cut through the noise of the assembled crowd, sharp and commanding. When the Herald spoke, his voice boomed with what Raxz could only assume was magical enhancement.



"My lords and ladies! His Highness, Prince Regent Raxz, and the Lady Marcella of House Kalvennor!"

Within the Grand Hall, every attendant and guest turned toward the doors. As one, they offered the perfunctory bow of respect—for the Prince, and for the lady he escorted this night.

As they walked through the sea of watching faces, Raxz felt the weight of their stares. *Why are they looking so intensely?*

Then he remembered what he was wearing. He fought hard not to blush.

Once they'd reached a suitable distance inside the hall, Lady Marcella turned to him, her expression polite but distant.

"My Prince, I must go pay my respects to my family. I see them over there." She paused, then added, "But please understand—I hope you will reserve the first dance for me."

Raxz inclined his head. "My lady, I take no offense. Family calls, and so does the realm. My father would expect me to make conversation with most of the people here. I fully understand, and I hope your family does not take offense if I attend to my own duties first." He allowed a small smile. "And yes, I will reserve the first dance for you. If you permit it, the last dance as well."

He bowed, kissed her knuckles with practiced courtesy, and they parted—each moving toward their respective families.

Walking through the crowd alone now, Raxz's thoughts turned immediately to Javelin. *Where could he be?* He knew Javelin would attend—he'd said as much—but Raxz had no idea what he'd be wearing or where he'd position himself. His eyes instinctively swept toward where Javelin's family stood in their designated section. Various aunts and uncles from the court milled about, but Javelin himself was nowhere visible.

Disheartened by his friend's absence, Raxz continued moving through the hall in a darker, more somber mood.

Then, out of nowhere, he felt a slight pressure at his waist and a whisper in his ear.

"You know, you're so good at not being noticed that you're practically terrible at it. I'm swimming in riches." A hand reached around and showed him a collection of trinkets—rings, brooches, pocket watches. "Look what I've been pickpocketing from your guests."

Raxz froze for a heartbeat. Stunned. Then slightly irritated.

But underneath it all, comforted. *He's here.*

"You do know stealing is prohibited," Raxz said quietly, fighting the smile threatening to break his composure. "At least... not unless I get my cut. Or rather, the crown gets its cut."

Javelin spoke in an almost wounded voice, but his eyes gleamed with mischief. "My Prince, corruption at your age? That certainly will not do. I'll have to report you to the proper authorities for extortion." He rattled the stolen trinkets. "These are merely items whose owners unwittingly asked me to hold in safekeeping. At least until the end of the night. Or until they pay to reclaim them. You know, ransoms don't always have to be about people." He chuckled softly.

Feeling outwitted, Raxz scoffed. "What you call bribery, the Crown Prince calls taxes. See? We can both get what we want and have fun with it. Isn't that the less—"

He stopped himself mid-word. Gathered his composure. "Isn't that the *example* you've always tried to give me?"

As Raxz and Javelin approached his family's high seat, the subtle chuckle he'd heard from Javelin died completely. They now stood before the Emperor's table—a magnificent example of power, duty, and sacrifice. In other kingdoms, other lands, such a table would be grand, polished, pristine—no indication of the trials the empire or its people had endured. But this table bore each and every mark of battle it had survived, serving as a reminder that the bounty of today was not built on ease, but on sacrifice and the nobility to persevere. That was what empire meant.

At the head of the table sat his father, Arctus. Regal. Formal. The chair beside him—where the Empress, or at least the Regent Consort, would sit—was empty. This wasn't new to Raxz. For years now, he'd suspected a division between families. His mother's own line had always been controversial, independent. The imperial family, by contrast, dedicated itself to more traditional forms of governance. Still, the absence stung.

Raxz bowed to his father. As he straightened, he found his gaze drawn immediately to his left, where Ellen sat. The second-born. Eighteen months younger. A woman formidable in her own right, and by all standards, arguably the better successor to the throne. She possessed the military knowledge and political acumen to become, if not the best empress this empire had ever seen, then at least its finest administrator and war tactician.

Raxz bowed in acknowledgment. "Sister. It is a pleasure. I'm glad your duties allowed you the privilege to join us."

Ellen met his eyes without reservation, her expression carefully neutral. She bowed in return. "My Prince. Duty calls, and I must answer." Her voice dropped, quiet enough that

only he, their father, and perhaps Theo could hear. "While the world and the Empire believe us to be the first among equals, we truly are merely the last among all of them."

The words settled between them like stones.

As Raxz straightened, he sensed a flicker of annoyance in the air—a presence radiating indignation. He turned.

Lance stood behind him, arms crossed, feet shoulder-width apart, wearing an expression of supreme smugness only a seven-year-old could manage. He looked up at Raxz with an imperious tilt of his chin.

"Well, I see what the staff was saying about a murdered peacock strutting around the Great Hall. I honestly didn't think it would be my own brother."

Raxz crouched to Lance's level and inclined his head formally. "My Prince," he said with exaggerated solemnity, then added, "Or should I call you Great Grand Prince? Your attire clearly tells me you pilfered our late grandfather's closet."

Lance's expression shifted to wounded pride. "I'll have you know this was chosen by the *best* tailors in the capital, and they told me I looked as regal as any Prince Regent!"

Raxz opened his mouth to reply with another quip when a piercing squeal cut through the air. A small figure darted out from behind Lance, sprinting toward him at full speed. It took him a moment to register what was happening—and then the candlelight caught her hair.

Silver woven through with twilight and morning's first light. Exactly like their mother's.

The sight struck him like a blow. For a heartbeat, he wasn't at the gala. He was five years old, chasing something beautiful and impossible through the Fields of Absolution, watching it land on a boy's outstretched finger. The boy had whispered so gently: "*What a beautiful little bird. What a shame it would be if someone were to put you in a golden cage.*"

Raxz whispered the words aloud without thinking. "What a beautiful little bird."

A moment later, the small body collided with him at waist height. He caught her reflexively, even though his mind was still trapped in that distant memory.

Millie looked up at him, her expression puzzled. "What do you mean, little bird? It's me. Millie. Silly."

Reality snapped back into place. The faint scent of grass, the breeze on his skin, the gentle voice—all of it dissolved, broken by the innocent words of a young child. Raxz looked down and saw his little sister: Millie, five years old, a presence impossible to ignore. It wasn't only because she was the lone deviation from the family's traditional black attire—though her

rich blue dress certainly stood out. It wasn't only the hair that faintly reminded him of their mother, a woman who now seemed more memory than person. He couldn't remember a time after Lance was born that he'd seen her clearly. But for Millie, he would try to remember what it meant to love someone unconditionally. Because that was all Millie had ever offered him.

*What a beautiful little bird*, he thought again. *What a shame it would be for you to live in a golden cage*.

He looked at her and smiled, speaking more to himself than to her. "The good thing is, you'll never have to live in a golden cage."

The last two words came out too openly. Too loudly.

Millie tilted her head. "Golden what?"

Raxz caught himself, realizing his mistake. He crouched lower, meeting her eyes, and said gently, "You look like a golden lily. Radiant and beautiful, as always."

Millie beamed, satisfied with the answer, and threw her arms around his neck.

Behind him, Lance tugged at his sleeve. "Don't ignore me! I'm here too!"

Raxz straightened slightly, now anchored by a five-year-old clinging to his chest and a seven-year-old attached to his leg. He glanced at Ellen, silently pleading for help.

Ellen's lips curved into the faintest smile. "You're the Prince Regent. Surely you can handle two children."

"I can handle ambassadors and generals," Raxz replied dryly. "Children are significantly more dangerous."

Theo appeared at Ellen's side, his voice low and efficient. "The first dance is about to be called. Lady Marcella will be waiting."

The warmth of the moment evaporated. Duty reasserted itself.

Raxz gently disentangled Millie from his neck and set her down. He ruffled Lance's hair, earning an indignant protest. "I'll see you both later. Millie, I promise you a dance."

"Really?" Her eyes lit up.

"Really."

He straightened fully, smoothed his ridiculous peacock attire, and turned toward the Grand Hall where Lady Marcella would be waiting. The weight of being Prince Regent settled back onto his shoulders—heavier now, somehow, for having set it down briefly.

Ellen's voice followed him, quiet but clear: "Eighteen months, Raxz. That's all that separates us."

He didn't turn back. He didn't need to. He knew what she meant.

*Everything. And nothing.*

As Raxz moved toward the center of the Grand Hall, he felt every eye on him. Judging. Laughing. Snickering. He ignored it out of duty, but deep inside, he burned to be free of this ridiculous attire.

When he reached the center where Marcella waited, he paused. Really looked at her. She seemed uncomfortable with the attention—perhaps from the cluster of male suitors from other houses surrounding her, competing for her notice.

He extended his hand and addressed the assembled gentlemen with diplomatic courtesy. "I apologize, but I must steal the lady away for a moment."

Without waiting for protest, he guided Marcella aside. He leaned in, voice low. "Forgive me. My familial duties kept me longer than intended."

Then, with deliberate formality edged with playfulness: "I also apologize for stealing you from what appeared to be a very enthusiastic court. I promise to try and compensate you for such a transgression."

Marcella regarded him with an expression somewhere between amusement and wariness. "No transgression taken, Your Highness. But I do believe you're being unfair. Many attending ladies would love to hold court with you, if only for an instant." She paused, her tone sharpening slightly. "Yet somehow, despite neither of us being particularly prepared for this, we find ourselves at an impasse. You appreciate my efforts. I recognize your value. But what, exactly, is the endgame in all of this?"

Raxz opened his mouth to respond, but from the head of the hall, Arctus's voice rang out, pronouncing the first dance.

Silence fell. The orchestra began—slow, gentle, building. The magical enhancements woven through the instruments gave the hall a sense of wilderness seldom experienced in modern imperial courts. Marcella looked up at him. Together, they moved to the dance floor.

Slowly, deliberately, Raxz placed his arm around her waist and guided her through the melody. At first their movements were measured, formal. As the tempo rose, they matched the beat—the orchestra playing with deliberate intensity. The music was visceral, intimate, almost uncomfortably personal.

As they moved past other dancers joining the floor, Raxz caught fragments of whispered commentary. A murmur here, a snicker there.

"A rainbow gone awry."

"The accident of a dyslexic artist."

Each comment landed like a small blade. What astonished him was that Marcella seemed utterly unaffected—if she heard them at all. But clearly, if he could hear them, so could she. Did she feel the same burning indignation he did? The humiliation of being mocked simply for conforming to protocol, for doing what duty demanded?

The righteous anger continued to build, slow and consuming.

The music shifted—rising to a high, intimate melody where the violin sounded as though it were crying for notes it had never known it could play. The intensity peaked. Then, as if inspired by sheer audacity, Raxz timed his next move to the precise moment when the violin sounded its last note.

A heartbeat of silence. The mournful cry of the instrument faded into nothing.

In that instant, Raxz focused his will. Warmth radiated from his chest, spreading outward. He understood exactly what he wanted to do.

A rose began to bloom—not physical, but spectral, made of light and magic—around him and Marcella. Petals of energy enveloped them in the bud. As the flower came to full bloom and dissolved, their attire transformed.

No longer peacock chaos. Now: imperial black, accented with gold and silver. Regal. Appropriate. Correct.

The moment lasted only a breath before the music resumed—this time more intense, more intimate. Marcella looked down at the change. Without missing a single beat, she continued dancing, pulling Raxz closer. Each step they took brought them nearer to an inevitability neither had chosen but both were bound to perform.

Raxz felt a surge of satisfaction. He had corrected the situation. He had given her dignity, taken them both from a state of mockery to something that reflected mastery and power. He had done her justice.

Marcella's response was to dance with even greater precision, proving she was fully worthy of such acknowledgment—someone of note, someone deserving great respect.

The music built to its crescendo. Their final steps brought them as close and intimate as the opening had been restrained. The melody died slowly, the final note lingering in the silence of the Grand Hall. Even after the sound faded, their movements continued—delicate adjustments, the acceptance and counter-acceptance of the dance's closing form—until the music died completely, not just in the air but in the hearts and minds of every watching guest.

Raxz looked down at Marcella. For an instant, they shared a glance. He saw her wanting to smile—but she couldn't find it in herself.

Applause began. Slow at first, building from the back and surging forward. Raxz glanced around, startled to find himself at the exact center of attention. Most of the noble houses applauded with enthusiasm.

But one section remained frozen: House Kalvennor.

Marcella met his eyes. Her expression was perfectly composed, her voice pitched just loud enough for those nearest to hear. "Your Majesty, thank you for the dance. Although the surprise would have been best if properly coordinated."

She offered a shallow curtsy—formal, correct, cold—and turned away.

As she passed the Grand Hall entrance, members of House Kalvennor stood and followed. They didn't look at the throne. They didn't bow to dismiss themselves. Protocol wasn't breached—they had fulfilled their obligation. But the message was unmistakable.

That message, Raxz realized with dawning horror, was louder and more devastating than all the applause that had just greeted him.

He looked toward his father. Arctus appeared unconcerned, almost aloof. He swirled wine in a crystalline goblet, studying it as though contemplating something far away. He took a sip. Tasted it. Then drained the goblet in a single motion.

Arctus glanced at Ellen—a brief look, as if sharing a private message Raxz was not privy to. Then the Emperor stood.

"My distinguished guests," Arctus announced, his voice carrying effortlessly across the hall. "Thank you for attending this evening's event. But I must excuse myself. The realm calls, and your humble servant must answer." He gestured broadly. "Please, continue to enjoy

yourselves. Do not let any request go unfulfilled. If there is anything I or my house can give to the realm, it is theirs."

Without another word, Arctus walked out through the exit near the imperial table.

The Grand Hall fell into uncertain murmurs. Raxz stood alone on the dance floor, the weight of what he'd done settling over him like stone.

Slowly, the murmuring started as Arctus departed. Raxz turned and began walking toward the nearest exit. As he moved through the crowd, guests approached to congratulate him on the beautiful performance, remarking on how masterfully he'd exhibited his magical prowess. He nodded, offered noncommittal gestures of acknowledgment, and kept moving.

As he neared the exit, he caught sight of Javelin in his peripheral vision. Mentally, he braced himself for what he knew would be a lesson in proper protocol.

That thought died the moment he felt a strong tackle from behind and heard a voice squealing with pure joy.

"Wow! That was so beautiful! Can you do the same for me when we have our dance?"

Raxz looked back and saw Millie clinging to him.

He exhaled, some of the tension leaving his shoulders. "Didn't Father just say that anything our guests want, they will be given?"

She giggled. "Absolutely!" She hugged him tighter, and for a brief moment, the weight pressing down on him lifted. This simple moment with her—uncomplicated, innocent—was the only genuine thing he'd felt all evening.

Javelin continued moving closer. Raxz felt the tension building again and deliberately ignored it. But before Javelin could reach him, Millie pulled back and said, "Oh! By the way, Sister Ellen told me to give you this."

She held out a folded note bearing the imperial seal.

Raxz took it carefully. The wax was still warm—written moments ago, delivered immediately. A letter from his father. No. From the *Emperor*. This was imperial business.

Righteous indignation flared inside him. How dare his father—no, how dare the *Emperor*—use his sister as a messenger? If Arctus wanted to summon him, he should have sent one of his numerous pages. But to use Millie? To burden this small, innocent girl with delivering what was clearly a rebuke? And worse—Ellen had been willing to pass the duty to her youngest sister rather than deliver it herself?



Raxz looked down at Millie and forced a smile. "Thank you, little bird. Now, why don't you go dance with Javelin? I heard he's been very sad and could use someone like you to make his day better."

He kissed her cheek and watched as she squealed with delight and ran toward Javelin. Javelin, caught completely unprepared, staggered slightly but caught her.

In the millisecond it took Millie to reach him, Raxz broke the seal and read the letter.

Two words: *My office.*

Truly, this was empire business. The Emperor only ever summoned him to his office if it was nothing less than imperial in scope.

The moment Javelin steadied himself, still holding Millie, he looked up and made eye contact with Raxz across the hall. They shared a single moment—acknowledgment, understanding, something unspoken passing between them.

Then Raxz blinked.

The air shifted as he reappeared. A subtle distortion rippled outward—a brief *pop* and the soft *whoosh* of displaced air echoing through the empty corridor. Raxz stood before the Emperor's office, two guards flanking the door like sentinels. They stared straight ahead, neither meeting his eyes.

He stared at the heavy wooden doors and felt dread settle over him like a shroud.

*Why the office?* he thought. *Why not Father's library? His private quarters? A neutral room? Why the Emperor's office?*

The distinction mattered. The office wasn't where his father lived—it was where the *Emperor* ruled. This wasn't a conversation between father and son. This was a summons between sovereign and subject.

The guards thumped their poleaxes against the ground in unison. The doors swung inward. Darkness yawned beyond the threshold.

Raxz stood frozen, hand half-raised to knock, staring into that darkness.

*What have I done?*

The question hung in the air, unanswered.

The doors remained open. Waiting.